Asking

A short guide to saying what you need.

A TOOLKIT FOR PEOPLE WHO WERE TAUGHT NOT TO

01 The condition

Some people learned early that needing something made them a problem. So they became very good at not needing. Or at needing quietly: hinting, over-functioning, waiting for someone to notice and feeling the silence when no one did.

The asks don't disappear. They go underground, into tiredness, into a resentment that has nowhere to land, into doing the thing yourself at three times the cost.

When an ask fails, it is usually not the need that was wrong. It is the shape. Too vague to act on ("I could use a hand sometime"). Buried under so much apology that the request gets lost. Or delivered at the moment of collapse, when nobody around you has room to hear it.

02 How to use this sample

Choose one ask that has been waiting. Not the biggest one. A small, real one, with a specific person in mind. Fill in the four parts on the next page once, in pencil. Then say it, or send it, within a day.

You don't need to explain why you need it. One sentence of context is plenty. The rest is yours to keep.

03 The four-part ask

Each part does one job. Together they make a request that is easy to understand and easy to say yes to.

1 · What is happening, in one sentence, without justification

2 · What exactly I need, specific enough to act on

3 · By when, or how often

4 · What makes it easier to say yes (an exit, a smaller version)

> AN EXAMPLE
>
> “My energy has been low most afternoons this month. Could you take school pickup on Tuesdays and Thursdays until the end of term? If a week doesn’t work, tell me the day before and I’ll sort it out.”

If it doesn’t land. A no to the ask is not a verdict on the need. Note it, then ask someone else, or ask the same person for something smaller.

THE FULL TOOLKIT

This is a two-page sample of *Asking*, a 14-page toolkit. The full version also holds:

— Scripts for medical, financial, emotional and practical asks
— What to do when an ask is refused or ignored
— Noticing the asks you already make silently, and call something else

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